

LEEKS *Allium porrum*

Hardy, resilient leeks can be planted to provide a succession of crops from late summer all the way through the winter months. Early varieties are generally taller, with longer portions of blanched stem, while later crops tend to be shorter, with darker stems and a tougher texture.

Delicious used in stews, casseroles, soups, or served up with white sauce, leeks are a versatile, valuable source of fresh winter food.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Although they will probably cope in any soil you care to plant them in, leeks prefer a deep, fertile soil with a slightly acidic pH. Dig in plenty of well-rotted manure or compost before planting.

Seed can be sown from as early as late winter in trays or modules under cover. Sow at a depth of 1 in (2.5 cm). Otherwise, sow successionally into an outdoor seed bed through spring; seedlings should be ready to plant out in eight weeks, when they are about as thick as a pencil.

Harden seedlings off before you transplant them. Trim their roots down to about 1 in (2.5 cm) and leaves to 6 in (15 cm). With a dibber, create holes about 6 in (15 cm) deep, and 6 in (15 cm)



Trim seedling roots before transplanting.

apart. Place the seedlings into the holes and water around them, allowing the water to drag the soil into the surrounding hole.

CROP CARE

Feed plants with a nitrogen fertilizer in summer, but do not overwater them. To give leeks their customary white stems, you will need to earth up soil around them as they grow.